

There was a lot of audience participation in this ceremony, from poems and readings to a live musical performance at the end. Set in a fabulous castle hall in Edinburgh, this was a festival of love celebrating the happy couple and their amazing families and friends.

INTRODUCTION

Can everybody please be seated and make yourselves comfortable.

A very warm welcome to you all on this very special occasion.

We are here in the Grand Hall of Craigmillar Castle to witness and celebrate the marriage of Ann and Nela. This is the perfect fairy-tale setting for an incredible gathering of family and friends!

It is wonderful to see you all, and Ann and Nela would like to thank you with all their hearts for being here to celebrate their wedding day with them.

My name is Stevie McLaren, and I am delighted to be here to conduct today's wedding ceremony and bear witness to the marriage of Ann and Nela.

I have been a Humanist Celebrant for five years, and it is moments like this that make me realise what a privilege it is! Today I am helping a very special friend marry her soulmate. It has been an absolute pleasure to be a part of Ann and Nela's wedding preparations over the last few months. They have tried to involve as many friends as they could, bringing together a wonderful group of brilliant and creative souls. I am so proud to be a small part of your gang!

This is what it's all about. People coming together to make something magical happen. So here we are, spending precious time together and sharing our happiness and love for this very special couple.

I have known and admired Ann for getting close to thirty years.

You must be thinking we must have met in nursery school??

Well, no, we're a bit older than that!

We actually met during the heady days of 90s grunge and techno, in the smoky haunts of Edinburgh and Dundee. We shared a love of music, creativity, herbal cigarettes and banter. So standing here as an old friend really fills me with happiness and pride.

It has been a joy for all of us to watch Ann and Nela light up each other's lives, and for everyone here, the love and light they have given us over the years has become this irresistible energy which fills our hearts with happiness and joy.

It takes courage to fall in love.

To trust someone with everything you feel.

To trust that someone will treat your weaknesses with care,
and to trust that our imperfections will not be seen as failings.

To love is the chain that holds our courage, hope, creativity and happiness together,
and inside every chain, there are tiny gaps that sometimes let the small things through.

So to love someone is to know those tiny gaps are there, and to ignore the small things because it is the big, beautiful and powerful things that make our lives so wonderful and worthwhile. Today, we celebrate the biggest wonder of all: We celebrate LOVE!

Love Story

Ann and Nela met and fell in love, and their lives changed forever.

As well as courage, it takes luck to fall in love, and our couple's lucky break came on the 4th of February 2011. They remember it well!

Ann and her friends were on a night out and had just arrived at the Cabaret Voltaire Nightclub.

Ann danced her way to the bar to get some drinks when she spotted a girl cutting some pretty decent moves. Being a reasonable dancer, she thought, “dance-off”, and without a single word, they locked eyes and danced in sync for the entire ‘choon’.

When the song ended, Ann asked if she could buy the girl a drink, and the pair hit it off whilst sitting at the bar. Their conversation was in full flow, but Ann's friends had other ideas! Around six girls spotted them at the bar, and for a bit of a laugh (for them), they piled on top of Ann, one on top of the other. Nela didn't know where to look! The girls laughed long and hard, and when the calamity calmed down, they left our couple alone to continue their conversation. Nela thought these girls were a bunch of weirdos, but secretly loved it.

Two weeks later, they had their first date (and kiss) at Paula's birthday party, and from that day, they were pretty much smitten and spent as much time together as they could.

Ann is a single mum, and she was setting up her own business at the time, so there was no such thing as a day off, but they made time for each other as best they could. Through their shared passion for music, food, dancing and travel, their love blossomed into what we see today. Nela has perfected the art of dealing with “Ann 1 & 2” and is now commonly known amongst their close friends as Mrs Wonderful.

Her calming manner, unending patience, loving kindness, and just being a genuinely lovely person have made Ann fall into the deepest love and admiration for her. Ann has been the Yang to Nela's Yin, and her healing hands and loving nature continue to lift her spirits whenever they are together.

Over the next eight years, their travels have taken them to Portugal to holiday with Nela's parents, Angus and Edith; to Ibiza for more dance-offs; Helsinki and Lapland for fun, culture and a wedding; the French Alps for skiing and snowboarding; Paris for romance and art; and lots of trips to London to see family and friends. Then there's the pilgrimage to Manchester for twinnery time with Erica, and 'Auntie Nela time' with Joe.

Ann's mum Sandra and husband Alan, John and Jenny, have all welcomed Nela into their family with open arms. This has been so important to Nela, and likewise, Ann has become a huge part of Nela's family. The welcome they both received has been amazing from the very beginning.

During the last eight years, Ann and Nela's love for each other has deepened beyond words; however, their lives have also been blessed by their families and friends.

You have shared so many incredible moments and celebrated all kinds of weird and wonderful life events - and, just as importantly, friends and family have helped each other through some of the tougher times. Ann and Nela want to tell you how much they love you, and how connected they feel to all of you today.

Ann and Nela enjoyed the holiday of a lifetime to the US, but it proved to be the holiday that changed everything. Their trip was all the more important because Nela planned to propose at the Pink concert in Boston. Nela waited until the last song to pluck up the courage. Ann, of course, said YES!!!

And their screams were joined by thousands of fans as the gig came to an end.

The whole experience was incredible, and the rest of the holiday was like a dream.

They went into Kleinfelds in New York, a famous Bridal Shop and TV show, and one of Ann's guilty pleasures - but they didn't get to try on any dresses or star on TV!

Then it was back to Boston for a spot of Whale Watching, and Goat Island for a five-star spa.

They came back elated and engaged, and couldn't wait to tell everyone their good news.

ERICA'S READING

Ann has been Nela's 'other half' for eight years - and soon she will **officially** be her other half!

But Ann has big shoes to fill, because Nela has had another half since the day she popped out with her identical twin Erica! Nela and Erica have always been there for each other. It felt like walking around

with a mirror everywhere you go! During the wedding planning, Erica has been incredible behind the scenes, and now she would like to join us 'on stage' and share a few words about her sister.

Can you please give your warmest welcome to Erica!

Erica reads.

Thank you, Erica! *Ad lib a wee compliment*

THE QUAICH CEREMONY

Ann and Nela will now drink from the Quaich, the traditional Scottish cup of friendship.

This amazing castle hall is the perfect setting for this ancient Scots' tradition.

The quaich has a long history because it was often used when our ancestors met and shared a drink, something we Scots do very well! The quaich became an important (and necessary) ritual.

By its shape, you are required to use both hands when you take a drink. In years gone by, this reassured Scottish clansmen and clanswomen that the person drinking with you wasn't able to reach for a hidden dagger. The quaich became a symbol of trust as it offered two hands in friendship - very reassuring when shady characters were hiding sharp weapons down their socks.

For today's happy wedding, the quaich is a symbol of trust as it symbolises Ann and Nela offering each other their hand of friendship, loyalty and love.

Ann and Nela, you will soon drink from the same cup. By doing so, you are declaring your commitment to share all that your future may bring. All the sweetness of life's cup shall be sweeter because you drink it together. Whatever trouble life may contain will seem less bitter because you share it together.

Erica can you please come forward and pour the drink into the quaich, thank you.

Erica pours the drink.

Erica, can you please present the quaich to Nela.

Nela takes the cup.

Nela, please offer the cup to Ann.

Ann sips

Ann, please offer the quaich to Nela.

Nela sips

Love is a powerful force, for through love, all that is bitter will be sweet;

through love, all that is copper will be gold.

With love, each new day is a sweetness you can give and a sweetness you can receive.

Ladies and Gentlemen, if you are starting to feel a wee bit thirsty,

the quaich will be taken downstairs to the courtyard where you are welcome to enjoy a hearty sip after the ceremony. We have three hip flasks here today, so please enjoy a healthy dram!

There is plenty of fine malt to go around!

SECRET PROMISES

A wedding ceremony like today's is truly special because it really is Ann and Nela's love in their words. This is their celebration, and the perfect way to show how much they mean to each other. We have enjoyed their story so far, and now we have some truly personal moments.

Ann and Nela would like to share some secret promises.

Neither of them knows what the other is about to say.

Ann, are you ready to read your words?

Stevie hands the card to Ann. She reads.

Thank you, Ann!

Stevie hands the card to Nela. She reads.

Thank you, Nela!

READING by Shay

One of Ann's oldest friends would like to recite a poem.

Shay and Ann happily reconnected last year when Nela and Ann went to visit Shay & Doug in Boston.

They went to the Pink gig together, so they were there when Nela proposed!

It is lovely that Shay would like to be a part of Ann and Nela's ceremony, so please, can you welcome Shay, thank you!

Stevie hands the card to Shay

These Hands

These are the hands of your best friend, young and strong and full of love for you,

that are holding yours on your wedding day,

as you promise to love each other today, tomorrow, and forever.

These are the hands that will work alongside yours, as together you build your future.

These are the hands that will passionately love you and cherish you through the years,
and with the slightest touch, will comfort you like no other.

These are the hands that will hold you when fear or grief fills your mind.
These are the hands that will countless times wipe the tears from your eyes;
tears of sorrow, and tears of joy.

These are the hands that will help you to hold your family as one.

These are the hands that will give you strength when you need it.
And lastly, these are the hands that, even when wrinkled and aged,
will still be reaching for yours,
still giving you the same unspoken tenderness with just a touch.

THE VOWS

Ladies and Gentlemen, Ann and Nela will now share their wedding vows.

Ann and Nela, can you please face each other and join hands.

Can you please answer your vows TOGETHER by saying WE WILL

Ann and Nela, will you accept and take each other to be your life's partner?

We will

**Will you solemnly and sincerely promise to cherish, love and comfort each other,
even when times are hard?**

We will

Will you respect, support and honour each other at all times?

We will

Will you forever share friendship, fun, laughter and adventure?

We will

Will you be trusting, loyal and forgive easily for the rest of your lives?

We will

Will you continue to have regular dance-offs?

We will

Will you have sweet dreams of throwing glitter in the air together?

We will

Will you remember the promises you have made and remain true to them?

We will

THE EXCHANGE OF RINGS

The wedding ring is a circle; a symbol of wholeness, strength, cooperation and peace.

The circle represents the seasons of life, and the circle of your rings represent your love for each other.

Your wedding rings will be a reminder of the vows you have just made

Erica, can you please present Ann's ring to Nela, thank you.

Nela, please take Ann's left hand. You may place the ring on Ann's finger.

Erica can you please present Nela's ring to Ann.

Ann, please take Nela's left hand. You may place the ring on Nela's finger.

Stevie hands cards to Ann and Nela and they read together.

This ring symbolises the infinite love I feel for you; I am yours, and you are mine.

THE LEGAL DECLARATION

Ann and Nela, I am pleased to report that you have completed the necessary preliminaries for marriage in Scotland and no objections have been lodged.

The legal impediments to marriage have also been explained to you.

All that now remains is for you to repeat the necessary declarations before me and in the presence of your witnesses and guests.

Ann and Nela, please hold hands and in turn, repeat the following declaration after me:

Nela, I turn to you first

I, NELA HOUSTON // solemnly and sincerely declare //

that I know of no legal impediment // to my marrying ANN CONSTABLE.

Ann, please repeat the following declaration after me.

I, ANN CONSTABLE // solemnly and sincerely declare //

that I know of no legal impediment // to my marrying NELA HOUSTON.

CAN EVERYBODY PLEASE STAND

Ann and Nela, you have chosen to become partners in the legal solemnity of marriage.
You have pledged your love, your respect and your commitment to each other,
having promised to stand by each other through whatever your lives together may bring.

You have exchanged rings to symbolise your loving commitment,
therefore, following the binding declarations you have made
it is my sincere pleasure and absolute privilege to hereby declare, that you Ann, and you Nela,
are now married in the fullness of Scottish and international law!

ANN YOU MAY KISS YOUR WIFE!
WHOOPING, CHEERS, APPLAUSE!

NELA, YOU MAY KISS YOUR WIFE!
MORE WHOOPING, CHEERS, APPLAUSE!

SIGNING THE DOCUMENT

Stevie tells the guests that we now sign the register.
Stevie reminds guests to keep cameras off until the photographers are finished.
*Stevie asks witnesses **Paula & Mandy** to come forward*
and with Ann and Nela, we go to the table with the Wedding Document.
Music, Michelle, please!
Dvorak - Romance for Violin & Orchestra

CLOSING CEREMONY

I mentioned earlier how important friends and family are to Ann and Nela.
By way of celebrating your circle of love, we will now enjoy a few words
from one of the Houston Clan's finest members.
Ladies and Gentlemen, can you please give your warmest welcome to Nela's Uncle Ian.

Ian reads his secret words.
Stevie thanks Ian, and he sits back down.

Bringing the wonderful spirit of love, happiness and togetherness to a fitting finale,
we will now be delighted by a song from Mari, Holly and Jenny.
Mari is a professional singer from Finland, and she has written the harmonies for today's performance.
Holly is an accomplished pianist, and Jenny is well known for playing double bass.

Today, in this amazing room, we will be enchanted by their voices alone.

Mari, Holly and Jenny will be singing a capella..

Ladies, can you please come forward, thank you!

The song they have chosen to sing for us is “All of Me”

The girls sing.

Stevie begins a round of applause and thanks the musicians.

Thank you!! That was amazing! Etc :-))

FINAL WORDS

Stevie tells guests where we will all go after Ann & Nela leave.

CHECK MUSIC READY - MICHELLE

Ann and Nela, congratulations on your marriage today.

May you continue to encourage and inspire each other -

and may you surround each other with peace, love and happiness for as long as you both shall live.

CAN EVERYBODY PLEASE STAND.

Ladies and Gentlemen, without further ado..

Or as Pink herself would say: “We better get this party started!”

It is my pleasure and privilege to introduce to you, for the very first time,

Please can you show your loudest love and appreciation for the wonderful,

the happy and the VERY NEWLY MARRIED,

ANN AND NELA HOUSTON!!

WHOOPS, CHEERS, APPLAUSE!